METHOCARBAMOL

May darken urine

Short-term use

CHEMICAL NAME (RS)-2-hydroxy-3-(2-methoxyphenoxy)propyl carbamate
CLASS Centrally acting skeletal muscle relaxant (carbamate)
TRADE NAMES Robaxin · Robaxisal (with aspirin)

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Acute painful musculoskeletal conditions (adjunct to rest, physiotherapy).
- Muscle spasm associated with tetanus (IV, adjunct).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** tablets.
- **IV:** undiluted max 3 mL (300 mg)/min, or diluted infusion; keep patient lying down 10–15 min after.
- **IM:** max 5 mL per gluteal site.
- IV solution is hypertonic — avoid extravasation.

DOSAGES

- **Adult PO:** 1.5 g four times daily for 2–3 days, then 750 mg–1 g four times daily.
- Elderly: half dose may suffice.
- **IV/IM:** 1 g every 8 h; max 3 g/day for 3 days.
- **Tetanus:** 1–2 g IV, then via NG tube up to 24 g/day.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** PO 30 min; IV immediate. **Duration:** 4–6 h.
- Metabolised in liver.
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 1–2 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- General CNS depression; inhibits spinal polysynaptic reflexes.
- No direct effect on skeletal muscle contractility.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Drowsiness, dizziness, light-headedness.
- Nausea; metallic taste.
- Urine may turn brown, black or green on standing (harmless).

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- IV: bradycardia, hypotension, syncope; phlebitis and tissue injury with extravasation.
- Seizures (IV, in epilepsy).
- Anaphylaxis (rare).

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hypersensitivity.
- IV form in renal impairment (contains polyethylene glycol).
- **Caution:** epilepsy (IV), myasthenia gravis, hepatic impairment.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Alcohol, CNS depressants:** ↑ sedation.
- **Pyridostigmine:** may reduce its effect in myasthenia.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- IV: give slowly; monitor BP and HR; keep patient recumbent.
- Check IV site frequently for extravasation.
- Assess spasm, pain and mobility.
- Fall precautions.
- Explain urine colour change.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- May cause drowsiness; avoid driving and alcohol.
- Urine colour change is harmless.
- Use with rest and physiotherapy; short-term only.
- Report rash or fainting.

KEY POINTS

- Central muscle relaxant for acute spasm.
- Harmless urine discolouration.
- IV max 300 mg/min; patient lying down.
- Adjunct in tetanus.

SOURCES CHECKED **[62]** Atmeksi, oral (US label) **[63]** Methocarbamol, IM, IV (US label)

Full references p. 432–457